



PARCHED HOPE

FIRST THE skies dried up. Then the land. Now, across swathes of India, hope is drying up as drought carves its scorching way through the kharif season. For this farmer in Rajasthan, the clouds in the sky are but a cruel mirage high above his misery.

LUCKNOW | Ringing in the Old

At a time when security agencies across the country are looking at going hi-tech, the Lucknow Police thinks harking back to the Raj is as radical an idea. The new SSP, Prem Prakash, has now ordered all station house officers in the city to revive ringing a gong in police stations every hour, a practice common during the British rule. The practice served two purposes—it worked as an hourly clock for those living near the police station and kept the cops alert. The return of the gong has surprised many of the rank and file, but it is part of the new SSP's long-term plan. Prakash insists that "it is the first step in improving the functioning of the lower rung police officials". Next on his radar are pot-bellied policemen; they will soon have to work on their girths and tighten their belts. Well, the bells are certainly tolling for Lucknow's men in khaki.

by Subhash Mishra

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



LUCKNOW COPS HAVE BEEN ASKED TO RETURN TO THE RAJ—AND RING HOURLY GONGS TO STAY ALERT.